Pemetrexed Monotherapy

One pemetrexed infusion on Day 1 of each 21-day cycle. Treatment is planned every three weeks while it is helping and side effects remain acceptable. There is no fixed total number of cycles in this regimen. Scans, symptoms, blood results, your priorities and the oncology review guide continuation, delays, changes or stopping.

Source reconciled; independent clinical, pharmacy and patient/PPI review pending. Selected effects; not a complete medicine leaflet.

A picture of side effects

Numbered symptom boxes connect to the anatomical illustration. The medicine responsible may be uncertain; report the symptom.

1 Mouth

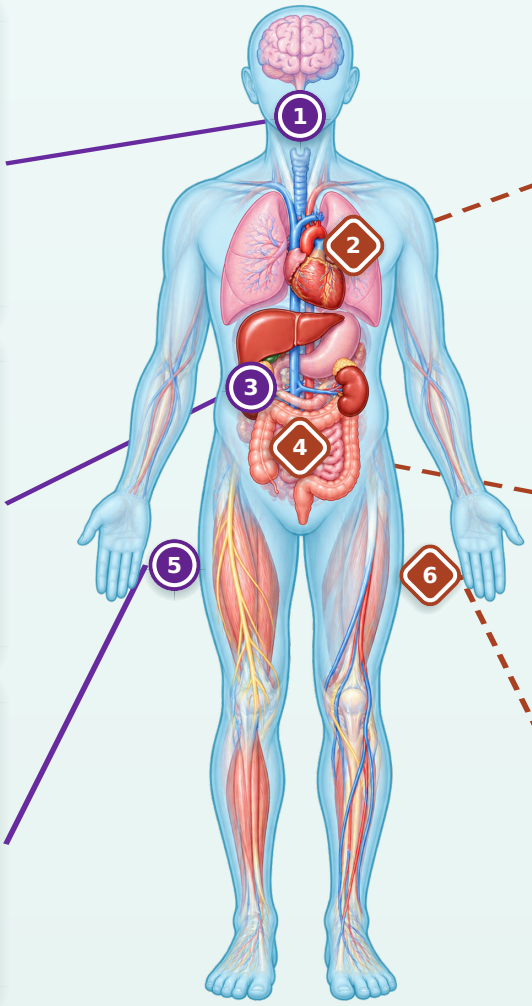
Pemetrexed

Report ulcers, painful swallowing or difficulty drinking.

2 Chest / breathing

Pemetrexed

New breathlessness, wheeze or chest pain needs urgent assessment; lung inflammation or infection can be serious.



3 Kidneys / fluids

Pemetrexed

Report reduced urine, dehydration or inability to drink; kidney tests guide treatment.

4 Stomach / bowel

Pemetrexed

Persistent vomiting or severe diarrhoea needs prompt advice; use prescribed anti-sickness medicines.

5 Hands / feet

Pemetrexed / prior treatment

Report new or worsening numbness, weakness, balance changes or difficulty with daily tasks.

6 Skin / blood counts

Pemetrexed

Report unusual bruising, bleeding or rash; fever or sudden illness needs immediate advice.

Selected effects, not every possible effect or a prediction. Blood-count, skin and line markers are schematic. Number and text carry meaning; colour is decorative.

Fever, shivers or suddenly unwell: contact oncology immediately. Severe chest pain, breathing difficulty, collapse or seizure: 112 / 999.

Your treatment, at home.

Important medicine-specific effects

Pemetrexed

- Low blood counts, infection and bleeding
- Nausea, vomiting and fatigue
- Mouth soreness and diarrhoea
- Kidney problems
- Allergic or infusion reactions
- Skin rash; rarely serious skin reactions
- Rare serious lung inflammation

Surgery, radiation and monitoring: open the whole-treatment map or scan the QR.

Make the plan practical

Folic acid every day

The source uses folic acid 350–1000 micrograms daily. Take at least five doses in the seven days before the first pemetrexed, continue throughout treatment and for 21 days after the final dose. Follow your own prescription and tell the team about missed doses.

Vitamin B12 injection

The source uses vitamin B12 1000 micrograms into a muscle during the week before the first pemetrexed, then every three cycles. Later injections may be on treatment day. A change from platinum treatment to maintenance does not automatically restart the B12 clock: your team checks the last dose and the next due date.

One steroid prescription

Pemetrexed rash prevention uses dexamethasone-equivalent 4 mg twice daily on the day before, day of and day after treatment. Your pharmacist or prescriber should give one clear steroid schedule that also accounts for any anti-sickness medicines. Do not add a second steroid course yourself.

Low-risk anti-sickness plan

Pemetrexed on its own has a low sickness risk. Take the prescribed prevention and rescue medicines and call if sickness persists. A previous platinum anti-sickness course should be reviewed when moving to pemetrexed alone.

Kidneys and other medicines

Check with the team before using ibuprofen, other anti-inflammatory painkillers, aspirin or any new medicine. Kidney function and the medicine determine whether and when it needs interruption. Do not stop a prescribed medicine on your own; ask for a written plan.

Reporting symptoms and getting help

Keep your 24-hour oncology number available, record symptoms and ask for practical or emotional support early.

Emergency: 112 / 999. Severe breathing difficulty, collapse, seizure or severe chest pain needs emergency help.

Contact oncology immediately for temperature ≥37.5°C or ≤36°C, shivering or suddenly feeling unwell, even with a normal temperature. Follow your own hospital's instructions. If you cannot reach the team, seek urgent medical assessment.

YOUR ONCOLOGY TEAM · DAYTIME

Insert numbers here

Acute Oncology Service

YOUR ONCOLOGY TEAM · OUT OF HOURS

Insert numbers here

Ask for medical oncology

EVENINGS / OVERNIGHT

Your out-of-hours pathway / nearest ED

Other hospitals: use the numbers your team provides.

Complete reference, visual timeline and passport

https://sactcheck.com/patient/00222/

Sources and review status are available online. Follow your own prescription and hospital instructions.